SYMPTOMS ACROSS STAGES

Over 30-40 symptoms can be linked to perimenopause, menopause and postmenopause.

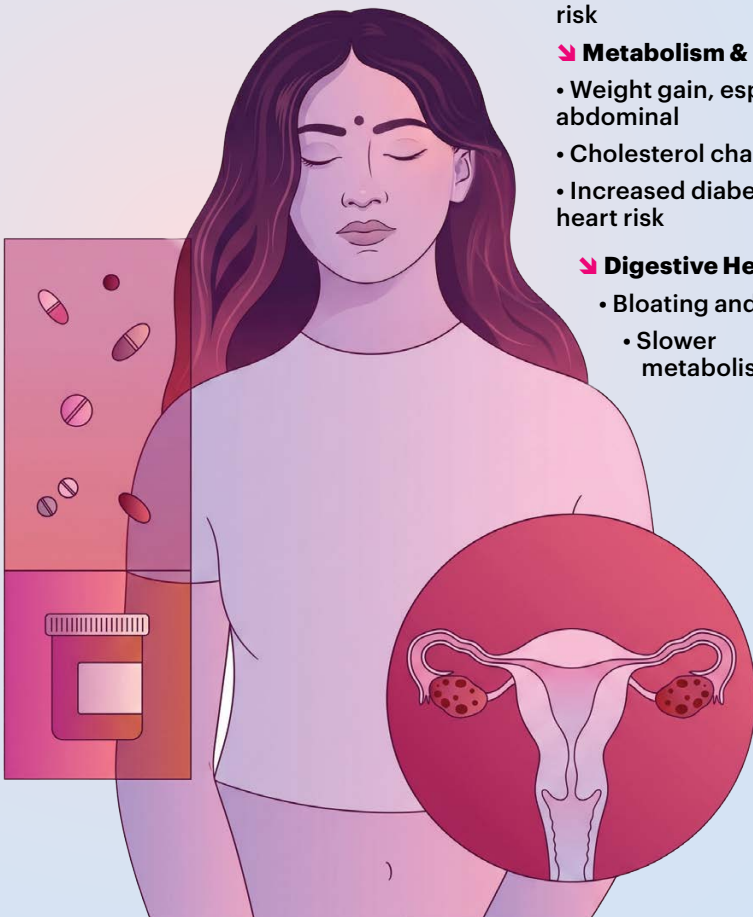
↘ Brain & Mood
- Brain fog
- Anxiety and irritability
- Memory lapses
- Mood swings

↘ Sleep & Energy
- Difficulty falling asleep
- Waking at 3 a.m.
- Chronic fatigue

↘ Bones & Joints
- Joint stiffness and pain
- Increased osteoporosis risk

↘ Metabolism & Heart
- Weight gain, especially abdominal
- Cholesterol changes
- Increased diabetes and heart risk

↘ Digestive Health
- Bloating and acidity
- Slower metabolism



Global research in the past two years draws a clear link between early ovarian decline and long-term disease risk. A 2023 study in *Human Reproduction* found that women who menopaused at or before 45 had a higher risk of all-cause dementia compared to those who transitioned at 46–50. Another 2023 systematic review reported increased risk of heart failure and atrial fibrillation among women with early or premature menopause. Bone health is equally affected. When bone density begins to fall early, bone turnover accelerates. International endocrine guidelines consistently warn that women with premature menopause or primary ovarian insufficiency face substantially higher lifetime fracture risk.

Ignorance is No Bliss

Unlike menarche, which is celebrated in many societies—from India, Africa, Latin America to even Japan—menopause is an unsung retreat into oblivion. It remained invisible because healthcare systems traditionally focused on fertility rather than midlife health. Dr Gayatri Muthukrishnan, co-founder of menopause support platform Miyara Health, says menopause was long normalised as ageing. "Millions of women experience symptoms but lack diagnosis or support because menopause has been treated as something women must simply endure," she says.

Social stigma, too, has hindered conversation on the subject, with menstruation taboos in conservative households extending into menopause. Most often, though, women lack plain understanding of why their bodies start behaving strangely. "Many women mistake early symptoms for stress or ageing and often rely on advice from friends or the internet instead of seeking medical guidance," says Dr Anita Gupta, senior director, obstetrics and gynaecology, at Fortis La Femme, Delhi. Reethi Rai, content and community head at Miror, another menopause-dedicated support platform, says the same: "As symptom patterns vary widely, many women initially are not sure that what they are experiencing is menopause-related."

For many women, this phase also often coincides with their peak career years and they fear being perceived as less capable if they exhibit any signs of vulnerability. Others are weighed down by caregiving duties for elderly parents or other family responsibilities, and so delay their own care until their symptoms become severe.

Waking up to the Worry

Until recently, menopause care meant treating symptoms like sleep loss, mood changes or joint pain individually. That is beginning to change. Several large hospital groups are launching dedicated comprehensive menopause services. Fortis Memorial Research Institute in Gurugram introduced its Maitri Menopause Clinic in 2024, offering multidisciplinary consultations along with hormone evaluation, bone density screening and metabolic risk assessment. Hospitals such as Max Super Speciality Hospital in Delhi and Fernandez Hospital in Hyderabad have expanded structured menopause consultations within women's health departments. States like Maharashtra and Kerala are taking menopause care to India's villages, with some hospitals setting up menopause clinics.